

MOVIE

Minnal Murali

★★★★☆ | While there have been a few Indian superhero movies over the past couple of years, most of them have gone with the western superhero formula and have little of what we can term as “Indianness”. Be it Bollywood superhits such as *Krishh* and *Ra.One* or South-Indian wonders such as *Velayudhan* and *Robot*, the movies are a little too disconnected from the desi environments in which they’re set. It pains us to say this but tacky Bhojpuri films such as the recently released *Nagraj* are more Indian than any of the aforementioned superhero movies.

Please note, a superhero movie doesn’t necessarily require the protagonist to have super powers, just being extraordinary in some aspect or the other usually makes the cut.

Minnal Murali is quite different in this regard. It’s set in the quaint village of Kurukkanmoola where the protagonist, Jaison played by Tovino Thomas, makes a living by running a tailor shop and hopes to migrate to the United States one day. Like most superheroes who tend to obtain their superpowers by an unforeseen circumstance, Jaison gets his superhero powers when struck by lightning. However, on the other side of the town, Shibu, the village outcast is also struck by lightning at the same time. Both individuals have their own personal problems and the way their powers manifest over time take different routes because of this.

While the protagonist’s journey is well-known and quite predictable, it’s the antagonist that really wins here. We’re not talking about evil trumping good but more about how good the antagonist, Shibu, plays his character. Guru Somasundaram has really done a great job here. Unlike what we usually see in superhero movies, it’s not pure villainy at play here. The evolution of the villain and how societal stigma forces the antagonist to act out is what makes the audience root for the villain. Berated and looked down upon his entire life because of being born as an outcast, the sudden onset of superpowers feels almost as if the world has provided him with a means to balance the scales and finally get what he’s wanted all his life. Despite that, he’s still not evil.

Intrigued? Well, now you have a reason to watch the movie. *Minnal Murali* does not force the western concept of a superhero until much later in the movie. It feels very much like a normal Indian movie and the characters are very much relatable. You won’t find an overdose of special effects or an army of earth shattering extraterrestrials in some outlandish doomsday scenario in *Minnal Murali*. What you get is the hero’s journey in a very Indianised fashion. How Indianised, you ask? Well, the Hero goes around wearing a lungi and a towel wrapped around his face to hide his identity. It doesn’t get any more real than that.

—Mithun Mohandas



UP AND COMING

TV SERIES

Peacemaker



If you’ve watched 2021’s *The Suicide Squad*, then you’ll be familiar with *Peacemaker*. In case you haven’t watched *The Suicide Squad* (why haven’t you?), *Peacemaker* – played by John Cena –

will do just about anything in the name of peace. And we mean anything. The upcoming series will serve as an origin story of sorts for the vigilante.

Release date: January 13, HBO Max

TV SERIES

Ozark season 4



One of the most popular crime dramas on Netflix, *Ozark* will conclude with its fourth and final season this January. This season will be a two parter, with the second part releasing later in the

year. The show follows the money laundering Byrde family who’ve managed to barely survive three seasons, but the fourth season’s synopsis suggests that things won’t be going too smoothly for them.

Release date: January 21, Netflix

TV SERIES

The Legend of Vox Machina



The legendary *Dungeons and Dragons* campaign is now being animated into a TV series. A group of voice actors came together and started a regular game of DnD, which would go

on to become popular web series *Critical Role*. Starring Matthew Mercer, Laura Bailey, Travis Willingham, Ashley Johnson, Taliesin Jaffe, Liam O’Brien, Marisha Ray, and Sam Riegel voicing their own characters, *Vox Machina* arrives at the end of January.

Release date: January 28, Amazon Prime Video